

APRIL 3
Deputy speaker of National Assembly Qasim Khan Suri rejects no-confidence motion on grounds of 'national security'; Imran tells people to prepare for polls in televised address; Pakistan **President Arif Alvi** dissolves National Assembly, fresh election to take place within 90 days



APRIL 2
Gen. Bajwa contradicts Imran's anti-US rhetoric, says Pakistan enjoys "close strategic relations with both China and US"

APRIL 1
Usman Buzdar resigns as Punjab CM; PTI announces PML-Q's Chaudhry Pervaiz Elahi as CM candidate

MARCH 31
In address to the nation, points accusing finger at US, saying it was angry at his foreign policy

MARCH 30
Ally MQM joins the Opposition

OCT. 2021
Engages in public stand-off with army chief **Gen. Bajwa** over replacement of Director-General of ISI Gen Faiz Hameed, whom Imran wants to continue. Bajwa has his way, Hameed is replaced by Lt Gen. Nadeem Anjum. Rift with army widens

MAR. 8, 2022
Opposition parties move motion of no confidence against PTI government

MARCH 23
Reaches Moscow; cuts short his visit next day as Russia invades Ukraine

MARCH 27
At Islamabad rally, Imran alleges 'foreign conspiracy' to topple government

DURING THE PTI'S TENURE, INFLATION, INCLUDING FOOD INFLATION, WENT INTO DOUBLE DIGITS, ENERGY PRICES SKYROCKETED AND THE RUPEE LOST ABOUT 50 PER CENT OF ITS VALUE

early in its tenure meant that it had burnt through about $6 billion in loans from China, Saudi Arabia and the UAE—almost the same amount as the IMF facility—before it finally accepted that it had no other choice.

Before coming to power, Imran and various PTI leaders had often spoken about the billions of dollars that would come into Pakistan as investments or which they would manage to bring back as "stolen wealth looted by corrupt politicians" such as former PM Nawaz Sharif and former president Asif Zardari. They managed neither. In fact, large foreign investment declined and the government was accused, fairly or unfairly, of having caused the flagship multi-billion dollar China Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) investment to stall.

Imran and his cohort had also promised to reduce fuel prices and debt. In fact, inflation galloped into double digits over the last three and a half years—it stands at about 12.7 per cent right now—and food inflation has been well above 20 per cent, which impacts the poorest sections of society the most. The Pakistani rupee has lost about 50 per cent of its value since the PTI came to power. Energy prices were increased massively. Debt, too, increased manifold, with the government borrowing more in three and a half years than the Pakistan People's Party (PPP) and Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N) governments in their tenures combined. The debt-to-GDP ratio went up to almost 87 per cent in 2020, though it now stands at a little over 80 per cent, primarily because of a GDP-rebasing exercise.

While Imran often touts the rise in exports and overseas remittances as his tenure's success, revenues have not kept pace with the growth of domestic debt. In fact, the rise in FBR tax revenues—from PKR (Pakistani rupee) 3.8 trillion in 2018 to PKR 6.1 trillion in 2022—has mostly been achieved through an intensification of tax collection from existing taxpayers rather than the promised broadening of the tax net. In 2018-19, 55 per cent of Pakistan's external receipts were eaten up by external financing requirements (interest payments etc.). The government managed to bring that down to 39 per cent in the subsequent two years, but IMF projections show that number is likely to climb back up to 51 per cent this fiscal year and to cross 67 per cent next year. The State Bank of Pakistan's foreign exchange reserves have also dwindled to slightly above $12 billion, just enough for perhaps two months of imports. Even Asad Umar, PTI's erstwhile planning minister, admits that the external situation will be challenging for whoever comes in as the next finance minister.

Although Imran blamed previous governments for having saddled his government with crippling interest payments, an artificially propped-up exchange rate and unsustainable public utilities, this was cold comfort for the vast majority of people. The failure of Imran's government to get a grip on the economy, particularly the rising cost of living, was perhaps the key factor in the growing disillusionment whether amongst the people or his erstwhile backers. Certainly, the